

SOC INCIDENT INVESTIGATION REPORT

Brewertalk.com Web Attack — BOTS v3 Dataset

Incident Date: August 20, 2018 | Report Date: June 2026 | Classification: CONFIDENTIAL

1. Executive Summary

This report documents a multi-stage cyberattack investigation conducted on the BOTS v3 (Boss of the SOC) dataset using Splunk Enterprise SIEM. The target of the attack was [www.brewertalk.com](#), a forum website owned by the fictional company Frothly. The investigation uncovered a coordinated attack involving web reconnaissance, automated scanning, credential stuffing, and data exfiltration — all occurring on August 20, 2018.

Five distinct findings were identified across four attack phases and attributed to multiple external threat actors operating in a coordinated manner. All findings were mapped to the MITRE ATT&CK framework.

2. Incident Details

Field	Details
Incident ID	BOTS-2018-001
Target Organization	Frothly (brewertalk.com)
Target System	brewertalk.com — MyBB Forum (Apache 2.2.34 on Amazon AWS)
Attack Date	August 20, 2018
Investigation Tool	Splunk Enterprise 9.x + BOTS v3 Dataset (143,661 events)
Analyst	Saniya
Severity	HIGH
Status	Investigation Complete — Partial Breach Confirmed

3. Dataset & Environment

Dataset: Boss of the SOC (BOTS) v3 — Official Splunk CTF Dataset

Total Events: 143,661 security events

Key Sourcetypes Analyzed: stream:http, stream:dns, wineventlog:security, xmlwineventlog (Sysmon), osquery

Primary Investigation Scope: HTTP web traffic (stream:http sourcetype)

4. Investigation Methodology

The investigation followed a structured SOC L1 threat hunting approach:

- Baseline Analysis — Identified all source IPs making HTTP requests and ranked by volume
- Anomaly Detection — Flagged external IPs with unusually high request counts
- Behavioral Analysis — Examined URI paths, HTTP methods, status codes, and user agents
- Attack Chain Reconstruction — Traced attacker activity chronologically
- MITRE ATT&CK Mapping — Mapped each finding to relevant TTPs

5. Investigation Findings

Finding 1 — Web Reconnaissance by 91.207.175.249

Attacker IP: 91.207.175.249 (External/Public)

Target: www.brewertalk.com (172.16.0.178, 172.16.0.145)

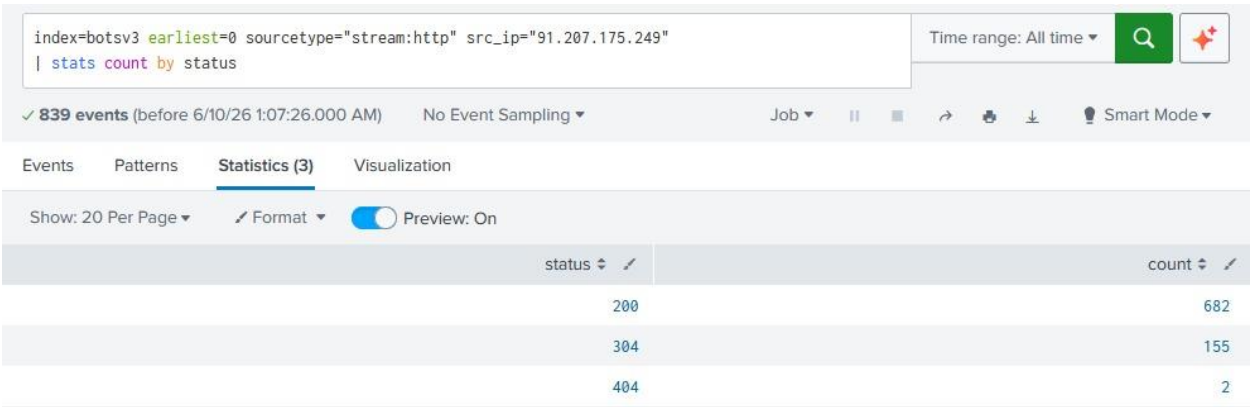
Time: August 20, 2018 — 18:40:27 to 19:19:53

Severity: MEDIUM

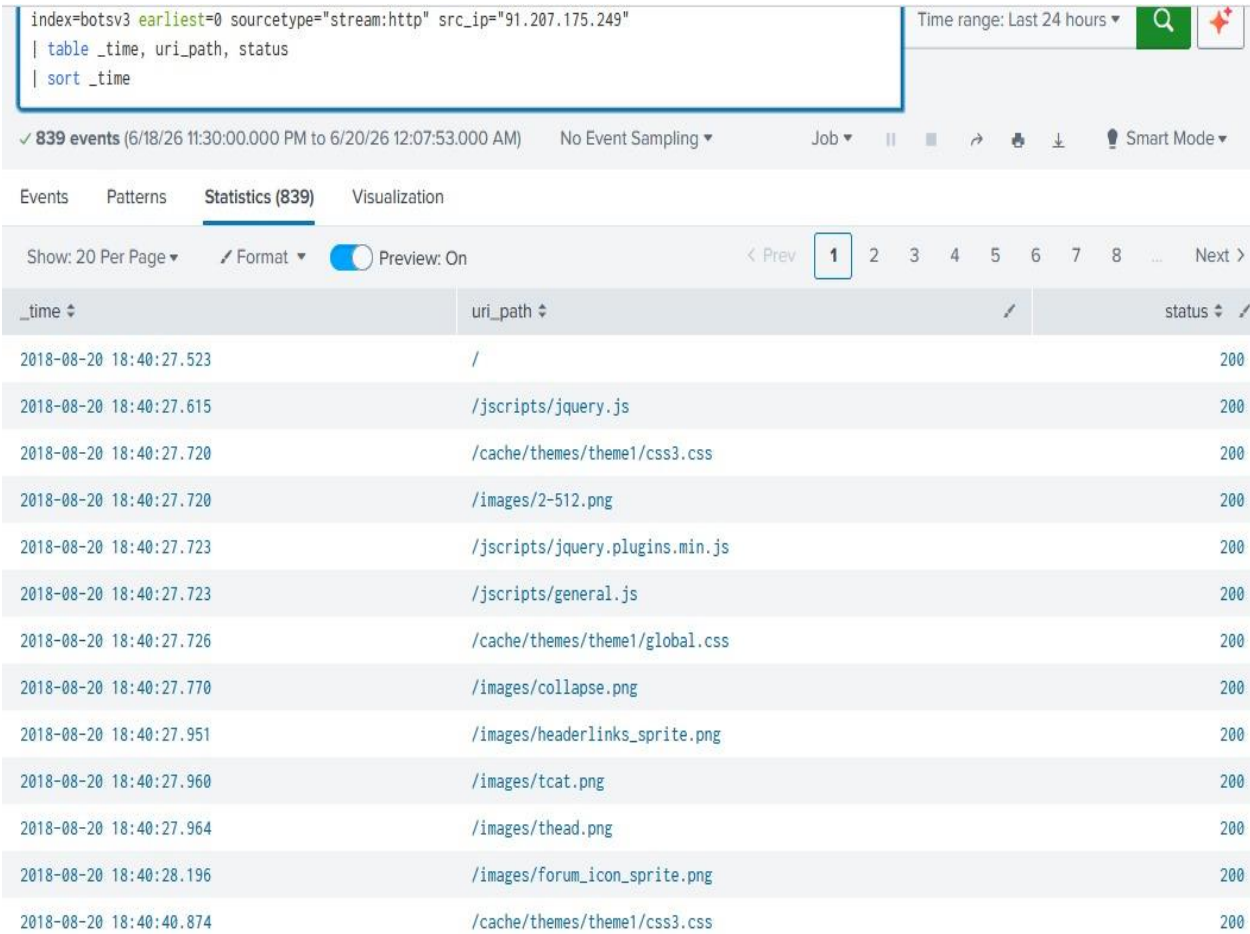
Description:

An external IP made 839 HTTP requests to the brewertalk.com web server, with multiple requests occurring within the same millisecond — confirming automated/scripted behavior rather than manual human browsing. The IP primarily used a Microsoft Edge browser user agent (791 of 839 requests, Chrome 64.0.3282.140 / Edge 17.17134), with a smaller portion (48 requests) using a different Chrome 67 signature — suggesting either multiple sessions or a tool reconfiguration mid-attack. The attacker systematically loaded forum pages and their associated resources, including the file attachment page.

Evidence:



Status Code	Count	Meaning
200 OK	682	Successfully retrieved content
304 Not Modified	155	Returning visitor — cached content (persistent attacker)
404 Not Found	2	Probed non-existent pages (scanning behavior)



index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"
| stats count by http_user_agent

Time range: All time

✓ 839 events (before 6/10/26 1:39:41.000 AM) No Event Sampling

Events Patterns **Statistics (2)** Visualization

Show: 20 Per Page Format Preview: On

http_user_agent	count
Mozilla/5.0 (Windows NT 10.0; Win64; x64) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Chrome/64.0.3282.140 Safari/537.36 Edge/17.17134	791
Mozilla/5.0 (Windows NT 10.0; Win64; x64) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Chrome/67.0.3396.99 Safari/537.36	48

index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"
| stats count by uri_path
| sort -count

Time range: Last 24 hours

✓ 839 events (6/18/26 11:30:00.000 PM to 6/20/26 12:11:49.000 AM) No Event Sampling

Events Patterns **Statistics (45)** Visualization

Show: 20 Per Page Format Preview: On

< Prev 1 2 3 Next >

uri_path	count
/cache/themes/theme1/css3.css	78
/cache/themes/theme1/global.css	78
/	66
/images/2-512.png	39
/images/headerlinks_sprite.png	39
/images/tcat.png	39
/images/thead.png	39
/jscripsts/general.js	37
/jscripsts/jquery.js	37
/jscripsts/jquery.plugins.min.js	37
/forumdisplay.php	30
/cache/themes/theme1/star_ratings.css	27
/images/collapse.png	27

Key Pages Accessed:

- /attachment.php — File upload/download page (potential vulnerability target)
- /forumdisplay.php, /showthread.php — Forum content enumeration
- /index.php — Homepage reconnaissance

SPL Query Used:

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"
| stats count by status

index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"
| table _time, uri_path, status
| sort _time
```

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"
| stats count by http_user_agent

index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"
| stats count by uri_path
| sort -count
```

MITRE ATT&CK Mapping:

Technique ID	Technique Name	Evidence
T1595	Active Scanning	839 automated HTTP requests
T1592	Gather Victim Host Information	Mapping forum structure and server info
T1190	Exploit Public Facing Application	Targeting /attachment.php vulnerability

Finding 2 — Automated Python Scanner: 35.182.246.222**Attacker IP:** 35.182.246.222 (External/Public)**Target:** www.brewertalk.com — All PHP pages**Time:** August 20, 2018 — 18:34 to 18:47**Severity:** HIGH**Description:**

A second external IP was identified running a custom Python script (identified by the user agent '__main__/0.2') that systematically crawled every PHP page on the website. Unlike the first attacker who used a spoofed browser, this attacker made no attempt to disguise their tool. The script hit every available page in a methodical, automated sequence over approximately 13 minutes.

Evidence:

index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="35.182.246.222"
| table _time, uri_path, http_method, status, http_user_agent
| sort _time

Time range: All time

✓ 197 events (before 6/10/26 1:28:37.000 AM) No Event Sampling
Job

Events Patterns **Statistics (197)** Visualization

Show: 20 Per Page
Format
Preview: On
1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 ...

_time	uri_path	http_method	status	http_user_agent
2018-08-20 18:34:52.269	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:34:57.062	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:35:31.461	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:35:41.207	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:36:26.861	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:36:32.884	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:36:38.051	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:36:48.200	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:36:53.269	/	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:37:02.368	/index.php	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:37:02.700	/portal.php	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:37:08.513	/index.php	GET	200	__main__/0.2
2018-08-20 18:37:08.838	/portal.php	GET	200	__main__/0.2

- User Agent: __main__/0.2 — Custom Python script (not a real browser)
- 197 out of 197 requests returned 200 OK — 100% success rate (no human gets this)
- Pages targeted: /, /index.php, /portal.php, /search.php, /memberlist.php, /calendar.php, /misc.php, /member.php, /forumdisplay.php
- Systematic sequential crawl — hitting every page category in order

SPL Query Used:

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="35.182.246.222"
| table _time, uri_path, http_method, status, http_user_agent
| sort _time
```

MITRE ATT&CK Mapping:

Technique ID	Technique Name	Evidence
T1595.003	Wordlist Scanning	Automated enumeration of all pages
T1594	Search Victim-Owned Websites	Full forum structure mapping
T1587.001	Develop Capabilities: Malware	Custom Python tool (__main__/0.2)

Finding 3 — Coordinated Credential Stuffing Attack

Attacker IPs: 157.97.121.69, 107.77.75.123, 12.196.122.127, 62.251.109.73, 174.215.8.112

Target: /member.php (Login page) — brewertalk.com

Time: August 20, 2018 — 18:37 to 19:17

Severity: CRITICAL

Description:

Five external IP addresses launched a coordinated credential stuffing attack against the forum login page (/member.php), generating 22 successful login POST attempts total (status 200). Request counts per IP ranged from 1 to 7, with 12.196.122.127 showing the most activity (7 attempts) and also exhibiting user agent rotation — switching from iPhone Safari to Mac Firefox within minutes — confirming automated/scripted tool behavior rather than a single legitimate user session.

Evidence — User Agent Rotation on 12.196.122.127:

index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" uri_path="/member.php" http_method=POST status=200 stats count by src_ip				Time range: All time	Q	
✓ 22 events (before 6/19/26 12:55:40.000 PM) No Event Sampling				Job		Smart Mode
Events	Patterns	Statistics (5)	Visualization			
Show: 20 Per Page	Format	Preview: On				
src_ip	count					
107.77.75.123	4					
12.196.122.127	7					
157.97.121.69	5					
174.215.8.112	1					
62.251.109.73	5					

_time	src_ip	status	http_user_agent
2018-08-20 18:45:03.236	12.196.122.127	200	Mozilla/5.0 (iPhone; CPU iPhone OS 11_4_1 like Mac OS X) AppleWebKit/605.1.15 (KHTML, like Gecko) Version/11.0 Mobile/15E148 Safari/604.1
2018-08-20 18:46:43.434	12.196.122.127	200	Mozilla/5.0 (iPhone; CPU iPhone OS 11_4_1 like Mac OS X) AppleWebKit/604.1.34 (KHTML, like Gecko) CriOS/67.0.3396.87 Mobile/15G77 Safari/604.1
2018-08-20 18:47:07.486	12.196.122.127	200	Mozilla/5.0 (iPhone; CPU iPhone OS 11_4_1 like Mac OS X) AppleWebKit/605.1.15 (KHTML, like Gecko) Version/11.0 Mobile/15E148 Safari/604.1
2018-08-20 18:47:52.476	12.196.122.127	200	Mozilla/5.0 (iPhone; CPU iPhone OS 11_4_1 like Mac OS X) AppleWebKit/604.1.34 (KHTML, like Gecko) CriOS/67.0.3396.87 Mobile/15G77 Safari/604.1
2018-08-20 18:48:17.151	12.196.122.127	200	Mozilla/5.0 (iPhone; CPU iPhone OS 11_4_1 like Mac OS X) AppleWebKit/605.1.15 (KHTML, like Gecko) Version/11.0 Mobile/15E148 Safari/604.1
2018-08-20 18:48:42.842	62.251.109.73	200	Mozilla/5.0 (Macintosh; Intel Mac OS X 10_13_6) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Chrome/67.0.3396.99 Safari/537.36
2018-08-20 18:49:15.295	62.251.109.73	200	Mozilla/5.0 (Macintosh; Intel Mac OS X 10_13_6) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Chrome/67.0.3396.99 Safari/537.36
2018-08-20 18:49:20.960	62.251.109.73	200	Mozilla/5.0 (Macintosh; Intel Mac OS X 10_13_6) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Chrome/67.0.3396.99 Safari/537.36
2018-08-20 18:50:03.441	62.251.109.73	200	Mozilla/5.0 (Macintosh; Intel Mac OS X 10_13_6) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Chrome/67.0.3396.99 Safari/537.36
2018-08-20 18:50:04.286	62.251.109.73	200	Mozilla/5.0 (Macintosh; Intel Mac OS X 10_13_6) AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko) Chrome/67.0.3396.99 Safari/537.36
2018-08-20 18:50:06.811	12.196.122.127	200	Mozilla/5.0 (Macintosh; Intel Mac OS X 10_13; rv:61.0) Gecko/20100101 Firefox/61.0

Time	User Agent	Verdict
18:45	iPhone Safari (iOS 11.4.1)	Spoofed
18:46	iPhone Chrome (CriOS/67)	Spoofed
18:50	Mac Firefox 61.0	Different OS — same IP! Confirms automation

Shared User Agent Evidence:

- 91.207.175.249 and 107.77.75.123 used identical Edge/17.17134 user agent string — likely same operator

SPL Query Used:

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" uri_path="/member.php"
http_method=POST status=200
| stats count by src_ip

index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" uri_path="/member.php"
http_method=POST
| table _time, src_ip, status, http_user_agent
| sort _time
```

MITRE ATT&CK Mapping:

Technique ID	Technique Name	Evidence
T1110.004	Credential Stuffing	Multiple IPs hitting /member.php with successful logins
T1078	Valid Accounts	Successfully authenticated sessions obtained
T1090	Proxy	Multiple IPs likely used to bypass rate limiting

Finding 4 — Data Exfiltration via Compromised Account

Attacker IP: 12.196.122.127 (External)

Target: /attachment.php — Forum file attachments

Time: August 20, 2018 — 18:38:57 and 18:51:57 (two bursts)

Severity: CRITICAL

Description:

IP 12.196.122.127 — the same IP identified in Finding 3's credential stuffing attack — bulk-downloaded forum attachments in two automated bursts: 7 files at 18:38:57 and 7 more at

18:51:57, each completed within a single second. This confirms the compromised account was used to systematically exfiltrate file attachments from the forum.

Evidence :

<pre>index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="12.196.122.127" uri_path="/attachment.php" table _time, src_ip, uri_path, http_method, status sort _time_</pre>					Time range: All time		
✓ 14 events (before 6/19/26 12:23:28.000 PM) No Event Sampling					Job		
Events	Patterns	Statistics (14)	Visualization				
Show: 20 Per Page Format Preview: On							
_time	src_ip	uri_path	http_method	status			
2018-08-20 18:38:57.426	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:38:57.434	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:38:57.454	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:38:57.454	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:38:57.483	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:38:57.496	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:38:57.519	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:51:57.052	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:51:57.052	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:51:57.066	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:51:57.076	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			
2018-08-20 18:51:57.081	12.196.122.127	/attachment.php	GET	200			

Attack Sequence: 12.196.122.127:

- 18:38:57 — Burst 1: 7 attachments downloaded in <1 second - 18:45-18:50
- Multiple login attempts (see Finding 3 for detail) - 18:51:57
- Burst 2: 7 more attachments downloaded in <1 second

SPL Query Used:

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="12.196.122.127"
uri_path="/attachment.php"
| table _time, src_ip, uri_path, http_method, status
| sort _time
```

MITRE ATT&CK Mapping:

Technique ID	Technique Name	Evidence
T1078	Valid Accounts	Used stolen forum credentials to authenticate
T1530	Data from Cloud Storage	Bulk downloaded attachments from AWS-hosted forum
T1119	Automated Collection	7 attachments downloaded in under 1 second

index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="45.7.231.174"				Time range: All time	
table _time, uri_path, http_method, status sort _time					
✓ 84 events (before 6/10/26 1:49:26.000 AM) No Event Sampling					
Events Patterns Statistics (84) Visualization					
Show: 20 Per Page Format Preview: On					
< Prev 1 2 3 4 5 Next >					
_time	uri_path	http_method	status		
2018-08-20 20:25:24.680	/	PROPFIND	503		
2018-08-20 20:25:24.963	/webdav/	GET	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:25.459	/wuwu11.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:25.967	/xw.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:26.490	/xw1.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:36.635	/9678.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:37.217	/wc.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:37.680	/xx.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:38.117	/s.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:38.769	/w.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:48.789	/sheep.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:49.539	/db.init.php	POST	404		
2018-08-20 20:25:52.697	/db_session.init.php	POST	404		

Web Shell Names Attempted:

- /wshell.php, /xshell.php, /qq.php, /sheep.php, /db.init.php
- /wuwu11.php, /ak47.php, /angge.php, /aotu.php, /cainiao.php
- /9678.php, /mx.php, /conflg.php, /lindex.php — all returned 404

Result: FAILED — No web shells found on server.

MITRE ATT&CK Mapping:

Technique ID	Technique Name	Evidence
T1505.003	Web Shell	Attempted to locate/access PHP web shells
T1190	Exploit Public Facing Application	Testing server for existing backdoors
T1595	Active Scanning	Automated scanning of shell filenames

6. Full Attack Timeline

Time (2018-08-20)	IP Address	Activity	Result
18:34 – 18:47	35.182.246.222	Custom Python script (__main__ / 0.2) systematically crawls entire forum — all PHP pages (Finding 2)	Success — full site mapped
18:37 – 19:17	157.97.121.69, 107.77.75.123, 12.196.122.127, 62.251.109.73, 174.215.8.112	Coordinated credential stuffing — 22 successful POST logins to /member.php across 5 IPs (Finding 3)	Success — accounts compromised
18:38:57	12.196.122.127	Burst 1 — bulk downloaded 7 attachments via /attachment.php in under 1 second (Finding 4)	Success — data exfiltrated
18:38	157.97.121.69	Rapid AJAX POSTs to /xmlhttp.php — 8 requests in 1 second	Success — forum manipulation
18:40 – 19:19	91.207.175.249	Browser-spoofed reconnaissance — 839 HTTP requests across 39-minute window (Finding 1)	Success — site mapped
18:51:57	12.196.122.127	Burst 2 — bulk downloaded 7 more attachments via /attachment.php in under 1 second (Finding 4)	Success — data exfiltrated
20:11 – 20:26	61.75.35.114, 45.7.231.174	Web shell scanning — POST requests to commonly named PHP backdoor filenames (Finding 5)	Failed — 404 all shells

7. All SPL Queries Used in Investigation

Query 1 — Identify Top Source IPs by HTTP Traffic Volume

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http"
| stats count by src_ip
| sort -count
```

Query 2 — Investigate Specific External IP Activity

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"
| table _time, src_ip, dest_ip, uri_path, status, http_method
| sort _time
```

Query 3 — Analyze URI Paths and Status Codes for Suspicious IP

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"
```

```
| stats count by uri_path, status  
| sort -count
```

Query 4 — Check Status Code Distribution for IP

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"  
| stats count by status
```

Query 5 — Check User Agent for Spoofing

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="91.207.175.249"  
| stats count by http_user_agent
```

Query 6 — Find File Upload Attempts (POST to attachment.php)

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" uri_path="/attachment.php"  
http_method=POST  
| table _time, src_ip, uri_path, status, http_method  
| sort _time
```

Query 7 — Find Repeated PHP File Access (Scanner Detection)

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http"  
| where like(uri_path, "%.php%")  
| stats count by src_ip, uri_path  
| where count > 10  
| sort -count
```

Query 8 — Analyze Scanner IP Activity and User Agent

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="35.182.246.222"  
| table _time, uri_path, http_method, status, http_user_agent  
| sort _time
```

Query 9 — Find All Successful POST Requests (Breach Detection)

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" http_method=POST status=200  
| table _time, src_ip, uri_path, status  
| sort _time
```

Query 10 — Confirm Successful Logins by IP (Credential Stuffing)

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" uri_path="/member.php"  
http_method=POST status=200  
| stats count by src_ip
```

Query 11 — Analyze User Agents for Spoofing Detection

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" uri_path="/member.php"  
http_method=POST  
| table _time, src_ip, status, http_user_agent  
| sort _time
```

Query 12 — Investigate Credential Stuffing IPs (Filter Noise)

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http"
| where src_ip IN
("157.97.121.69", "107.77.75.123", "12.196.122.127", "62.251.109.73")
| where NOT like(uri_path, "%.css")
| where NOT like(uri_path, "%.js")
| where NOT like(uri_path, "%.png")
| where NOT like(uri_path, "%.ico")
| table _time, src_ip, uri_path, http_method, status
| sort _time
```

Query 13 — Confirm Data Exfiltration via Attachment Downloads

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="12.196.122.127"
uri_path="/attachment.php"
| table _time, src_ip, uri_path, http_method, status
| sort _time
```

Query 14 — Investigate Web Shell Scanning (IP 1)

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="61.75.35.114"
| table _time, src_ip, uri_path, http_method, status
| sort _time
```

Query 15 — Investigate Web Shell Scanning (IP 2)

```
index=botsv3 earliest=0 sourcetype="stream:http" src_ip="45.7.231.174"
| table _time, src_ip, uri_path, http_method, status
| sort _time
```

8. MITRE ATT&CK Summary

Technique ID	Technique Name	Tactic	Finding
T1595	Active Scanning	Reconnaissance	Findings 1, 2, 5
T1592	Gather Victim Host Info	Reconnaissance	Finding 1
T1594	Search Victim-Owned Websites	Reconnaissance	Finding 2
T1587.001	Develop Capabilities	Resource Development	Finding 2
T1190	Exploit Public Facing Application	Initial Access	Findings 1, 5
T1110.004	Credential Stuffing	Credential Access	Finding 3
T1078	Valid Accounts	Initial Access / Defense Evasion	Findings 3, 4
T1505.003	Web Shell	Persistence	Finding 5 (attempted)

Technique ID	Technique Name	Tactic	Finding
T1119	Automated Collection	Collection	Finding 4
T1530	Data from Cloud Storage	Exfiltration	Finding 4

9. Recommendations

Immediate Actions

- BLOCK all identified attacker IPs at the firewall: 91.207.175.249, 35.182.246.222, 157.97.121.69, 107.77.75.123, 12.196.122.127, 62.251.109.73, 174.215.8.112, 61.75.35.114, 45.7.231.174
- RESET credentials for all accounts accessed by attacker IPs — prioritize accounts accessed by 12.196.122.127 which confirmed bulk attachment downloads
- AUDIT all attachments downloaded by attacker IPs to determine data exposure
- PATCH MyBB forum software to latest version — disable /attachment.php if not needed

Short-Term Actions

- Implement rate limiting on /member.php login page — max 5 attempts per IP per minute
- Enable CAPTCHA on login and registration pages
- Add WAF rule to specifically block requests containing "__main__" in user agent string — directly identified attack tool signature from Finding 2
- Enable MFA (Multi-Factor Authentication) for all forum accounts

Long-Term Actions

- Upgrade Apache 2.2.34 — this version has known vulnerabilities
- Implement HTTPS (SSL/TLS) — currently running on HTTP (unencrypted)
- Deploy IDS/IPS rules to detect credential stuffing patterns
- Set up automated alerts in Splunk for: external IPs making >100 requests/minute, POST requests to PHP files, user agent anomalies

10. Conclusion

This investigation successfully identified and documented a coordinated, multi-stage cyberattack against brewertalk.com. The attack involved at least 9 external IP addresses working in a coordinated manner across reconnaissance, scanning, credential stuffing, and data exfiltration phases.

The most critical confirmed breach was the bulk automated download of 14 forum attachments by IP 12.196.122.127 across two separate bursts (18:38:57 and 18:51:57), with the same IP

also conducting 7 credential stuffing attempts against the login page. Web shell planting attempts by two additional IPs failed, suggesting the attackers may have been attempting to establish persistent access after the initial breach.

The overlapping timeline of attachment downloads and login attempts by 12.196.122.127 suggests the attacker may have had prior session access or exploited a guest/unauthenticated access vulnerability in the MyBB forum software.

All findings were identified through systematic SPL query analysis in Splunk and mapped to the MITRE ATT&CK framework, demonstrating the value of SIEM-based threat investigation in detecting and documenting complex attack chains.

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